

Chapter 2: Ancestral Intruder

The man did not call Mara an alien.

He called her an ancestor.

Somehow, that was worse.

He stood in the open doorway wearing a dark coat fastened at the throat. His hair was silver-black, his face narrow, his eyes fixed on Eliya's body as if the verdict had already been decided.

Behind him, a woman held a ring of clear glass between both hands. A third figure waited near the corridor, one palm raised.

Eliya knew what they were.

Accord enforcement.

The fear was hers.

Mara felt it anyway.

"Eliya Sol," the silver-haired man said. "State your full cognitive identity."

Mara opened her mouth.

Do not speak, Eliya warned.

Mara shut it.

The man noticed.

"Eliya Sol," he repeated. "State your full cognitive identity."

Eliya pushed toward the mouth.

It was not physical, but Mara felt it like pressure behind her teeth. The body's lips parted.

"My name is—"

The voice broke.

Mara's panic tangled with Eliya's will. The throat seized. Breath stuttered. The body trembled between two commands and obeyed neither.

The woman with the glass ring stepped closer.

“No,” Mara said.

The word came out before she could stop it.

Everyone went still.

Eliya’s anger flashed hot.

You used my mouth.

“I’m sorry.”

Stop apologizing with stolen lungs.

The woman lifted the ring.

A pale beam passed over Eliya’s face. It moved deeper than light should go, through skin, nerve, memory, thought. For one second, Mara felt herself outlined inside another person’s mind.

The woman lowered the ring.

“Secondary awareness confirmed.”

The third figure whispered a word Mara understood through Eliya’s dread.

Violation.

Mara stepped back until the body hit the wall.

“I’m part of a peaceful mission,” she said quickly. “My name is Mara Venn. I came from Earth. I was sent to observe.”

The woman looked at the man.

The man’s expression changed.

Not surprise.

Recognition.

Mara felt Eliya react too.

Mara Venn.

The name had weight here.

History.

Warning.

“You know me?” Mara asked.

The man ignored the question.

“From which Earth authority?”

“The International Temporal Research Coalition. Lumen Gate Division. Geneva facility.”

The woman’s mouth tightened.

“Old architecture.”

Old?

Mara stared at her.

The wall sealed behind them without a sound.

Eliya’s fear sharpened.

They are containing us.

“For your protection,” the man said.

“Do not say protection,” Eliya snapped.

Mara had not chosen the words.

They came in Eliya’s voice, full of Eliya’s fury.

For the first time, the man looked uncertain.

“Eliya?”

“She’s still here,” Mara said. “I didn’t erase her. I didn’t even know she would be conscious.”

“And yet you are operating her body.”

“I don’t know how to stop.”

“Then you should not have entered.”

“I was told it was safe.”

“For whom?”

Mara had no answer.

The man stepped closer.

“My name is Kael Orison. I investigate ancestral intrusions under the Asterion Accord.”

“Ancestral intrusions?”

“Earth-origin minds entering sovereign descendants without consent.”

Descendants.

Mara’s thoughts snagged on the word.

“This is a human world?”

Kael studied her.

“What did they tell you?”

“That each star exists in a different era. That awareness could cross the boundary into compatible minds for passive observation.”

“Compatible,” Kael said coldly. “That is what your century calls it?”

Eliya’s bitterness moved through them.

We call it violation.

Mara looked down at Eliya’s hands.

The black ring.

The silver scar.

The trembling.

“I didn’t choose Eliya.”

“No,” Kael said. “Someone chose her for you.”

The words landed too close to something Mara was not ready to think about.

Dr. Soren Vale returned to her in a flash: his hand on the glass above her face, his calm voice before the Gate opened.

We will bring you home, Mara.

“My body is still on Earth,” she said. “If you damage the link, you could kill me.”

The woman with the ring looked away.

Kael’s expression shifted.

Pity.

Mara hated it immediately.

“What?” she asked.

Kael crouched so his eyes were level with Eliya’s.

“How long do you believe you have been here?”

“Twelve minutes,” Mara said. “Maybe less.”

Eliya went silent inside her.

Kael exhaled.

“Your first measurable intrusion occurred three days ago.”

“No.”

“Eliya Sol collapsed during a public archive session. She remained unconscious for thirty-one hours. When she woke, her cognitive readings showed foreign activity.”

“No. I just woke up.”

“From your perspective, perhaps.”

“The mission window was twelve minutes.”

“That may be what Earth told you.”

The room seemed to tilt.

“My body is in Geneva.”

Kael’s voice softened.

“Mara Venn, your origin body failed three hours after insertion.”

The sentence made no sense.

“No.”

“Earth declared you dead.”

“No.”

“Your name appears in multiple intrusion records after that date.”

Mara slid down the wall until Eliya’s knees struck the floor.

Pain sparked through borrowed bone.

Eliya said nothing.

That silence was worse than accusation.

Mara saw the chamber again. White lights. Cold glass. Dr. Vale watching her like a man watching history open.

We will bring you home.

He had lied.

Or failed.

Or never meant it.

“I’m not dead,” Mara whispered.

Kael looked at her with terrible steadiness.

“Not to yourself.”

The woman touched a symbol in the air. Pale restraints appeared around Eliya’s wrists. They did not touch the skin, but when Mara tried to move, the hands stayed locked in place.

Eliya’s hatred rose through their shared chest.

These are for mind-criminals.

“I’m not a criminal,” Mara whispered.

You are wearing my hands.

Kael stood.

“Eliya Sol, by authority of the Asterion Accord, you are under protective seizure pending separation.”

“Protective?”

“For the host.”

The restraints pulled the body upright.

Mara fought by instinct.

Eliya fought too.

Not with her.

Against everyone.

The body jerked violently.

The woman raised the glass ring.

“Cognitive fracture risk.”

Kael’s jaw tightened.

“Stabilize them.”

Pain exploded behind Mara’s eyes.

She screamed.

Eliya screamed with her.

For one terrible moment, there were no separate voices. No Mara. No Eliya. Only one body drowning in two lives.

Then the pain vanished.

Mara collapsed to her knees, gasping.

Kael's boots entered her vision.

His voice came from above, low and merciless.

"You are not the first Earth has sent," he said. "You are only the first who still believes she is innocent."

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